

166 NAZI INVASION OF POLAND

month. Merchant ships traveled in convoy to increase the chances of supplies getting through on each journey, but casualties were high.

Fighting the USSR

In June 1941, Britain gained a new ally when Germany invaded the USSR in Operation Barbarossa. Hitler had looked to the Soviet Union for new territory for the German people. It would also remove any future threat from the east but fundamentally followed through on Hitler's plan to destroy communism. At first it looked as if Germany and its allies would be as successful against the Russians as it had been against the French. By winter, Germany had advanced to within 1 mile (1.5 km) of Moscow, and Leningrad, the USSR's second city, was under siege.

Another powerful rationale for war in the east was one based on racist ideology and Hitler's hatred of Slavs and Jews. As German troops swept into Russia, they inflicted a terrible campaign of genocide against communists and Jews. Russian troops endured extreme hardships. German tanks plowed through the Red Army defenses. Prisoners of war were shot or left to starve. Fleeing civilians were butchered without a moment's hesitation. The harshness of the Russian winter slowed the Germans, and Russian counterattacks drove back their front line by several hundred miles. In the Battle of Moscow, from early October 1941 to January 1942, an estimated 650,000 soldiers from the Soviet Army lost their lives. In the spring of 1942, the Germans



Operation Barbarossa, launched in June 1941, saw the invasion of the Soviet Union by Germany, in breach of the nonaggression pact the two countries had signed two years earlier.



General Dwight D. Eisenhower led the Allied forces during the Normandy landings of June 1944. The invasion was a decisive step toward taking Europe back from the Nazis.

resumed their offensive in the USSR, driving the Red Army back and coming close to taking the Russian oilfields.

The Pacific and Africa

In December 1941, Japan entered the war by attacking the US fleet at Pearl Harbor, in the Hawaiian Islands, as part of its plan to drive American forces out of the Pacific. Germany—which had a tripartite agreement with Japan and Italy to provide mutual military assistance in the event any one of them was attacked by a nation not already involved in the war—immediately declared war on the United States. Britain now had two strong allies, the USSR under Joseph Stalin, and the US, led by President Franklin D. Roosevelt. Both were decisive in bringing about the defeat of the Axis powers. American industry became a triumph of wartime production, giving Americans in combat in Europe and Asia the tools they needed to fight the Axis.

Japan won quick victories in the Pacific. It successfully captured the Philippines, Malaya, Burma, Indonesia, and Singapore, Britain's main naval base in East Asia.

In North Africa, meanwhile, a renewed Axis offensive led by General Erwin Rommel brought the German and Italian armies within striking distance of Cairo and the Suez Canal. The first major Allied victory came in Egypt. In July 1942, Rommel was halted at El Alamein; in October, he was forced into retreat by the British 8th Army, led by Field Marshal Montgomery.